

TRADE AND LEISURE

It is 1331, and the sultan's palace is buzzing with activity. Merchants sail in and out, bringing goods from far-off lands. Together with other visitors, they wait in a courtyard in hope of an audience with the sultan. He, however, is in no rush. The sultan is relaxing in his family quarters, preparing to bathe in the cooling waters of his private octagon-shaped pool.



7 New arrivals

Porters and sailors carry up precious wares from the dhow docked below the steps.

8 Elephant tusks

Enormous tusks from the kingdom of Great Zimbabwe are on show in the courtyard.

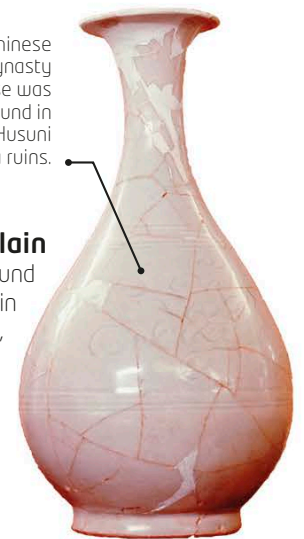


Niches in the walls were filled with precious objects.

Women's quarters

The women and children of the sultan's family spent their time in the private quarters, away from visitors. Their rooms were very beautiful, with elaborate patterns and niches decorating the walls.

This Chinese Yuan Dynasty vase was found in the Husuni Kubwa ruins.



Imported porcelain

Many ceramics have been found at Husuni Kubwa. Fine porcelain was imported from Arabia, Persia, India, and China. Fragments of pottery were often plastered into the palace walls in intricate patterns.

Triangular lateen sail



Dhow traffic

Cargo boats called dhows criss-crossed the Indian Ocean. They had one or two masts and slanted triangular sails. Large dhows sailed the open ocean, while smaller ones made shorter trips along the Swahili coast.

Pieces made from polished seeds



Bao board

The game known as *bao* in Swahili was popular here in medieval times, and is still played today. Two players take turns to move their pieces around the dips in the board, trying to capture each other's pieces.